

CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

Cross-Text Connections

A complete strategy for comparing two texts — with eight fully worked examples

What Is a Cross-Text Connections Question?

The Format

You're given two short passages — Text 1 and Text 2 — on a related topic, each expressing a specific claim or point of view.

The question then asks how the two claims relate: does Text 2 agree with Text 1? Challenge it? Add a new angle? Or how would one author likely react to a specific claim made by the other?

Why They Feel Harder

- 1 Twice as much text to read in the same time limit
- 2 You must track two authors' points of view, not one
- 3 The question asks you to extrapolate a reaction, not just recall a fact
- 4 Answer choices often restate a true detail — from the wrong text, or unconnected to the actual claim

THE STRATEGY

The Method: Paraphrase → Compare → Predict

Do this work before you ever look at the answer choices.

1

Paraphrase Text 1

Strip away the specific evidence and state the author's core claim in one plain sentence.

2

Paraphrase Text 2

Do the same for the second text. Give extra attention to how it treats the topic from Text 1.

3

Name the Relationship

Ask: agree, disagree, extend, or qualify?
State it in your own words before reading choices.

Four Relationship Types

Nearly every pair of texts falls into one of these. Naming it tells you which answer family to look in.

AGREE

Both authors reach the same conclusion — sometimes via different evidence or a different route.

DISAGREE

The authors reach opposite conclusions, or one directly challenges the other's evidence or reasoning.

EXTEND

Text 2 builds on Text 1 with a new, consistent angle — without contradicting it.

QUALIFY

Text 2 accepts part of Text 1's claim but adds a condition, exception, or limitation that narrows it.

Common Traps to Avoid

×	Restates a detail, misses the point	A choice can accurately quote something from a text and still fail to address the specific claim or relationship the question asks about.
×	Introduces outside information	If a choice brings in a fact that appears in neither text, eliminate it — no matter how plausible it sounds.
×	Overstates the relationship	Correct answers are usually measured. Watch for absolute words like 'never,' 'proves,' 'completely,' or 'universally.'
×	Swaps who believes what	A choice may accurately describe a view — but attribute it to the wrong author. Always check the source.
×	Gets the direction backward	A choice may describe agreement when the real relationship is a challenge, or vice versa — the classic reversal trap.

Office Space & Remote Work

TEXT 1

Economist Priya Nadkarni argues that remote work permanently reduced demand for downtown office space, pointing to vacancy rates that have remained elevated for over three years despite repeated employer mandates for a full return to the office.

TEXT 2

A 2024 survey of 500 companies found that 68% now require at least three days per week in the office, up from 41% a year earlier, and that companies report steadily rising compliance with these mandates each quarter.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to Nadkarni's claim in Text 1?

A. By agreeing completely, since both texts describe permanently reduced office demand.

C. By arguing that vacancy rates are an unreliable measure of office demand.

B. By suggesting that the trend Nadkarni describes may be reversing, based on rising mandate compliance. ✓

D. By claiming that remote work never significantly affected office space demand in the first place.

Why: Paraphrase: Text 1 = 'remote work permanently cut office demand.' Text 2 = 'mandates and compliance are both rising, quarter over quarter.' Text 2's data doesn't confirm 'permanent' — it points the opposite way, so it qualifies rather than agrees.

Handwritten vs. Typed Notes

TEXT 1

When students take handwritten notes, the physical act of writing slower than speech forces them to summarize and paraphrase what a speaker says, rather than transcribing it verbatim. This selective processing, researchers argue, is what makes handwritten notes more effective for long-term retention than typed notes.

TEXT 2

A follow-up study equipped some laptop note-takers with software that disabled verbatim transcription, forcing them to type in short, summarized bursts similar to handwriting speed. These restricted laptop users performed as well on retention tests as handwritten note-takers, while unrestricted laptop typists performed significantly worse.

Based on the texts, what would the author of Text 2 most likely say about the claim in Text 1 that handwriting itself drives better retention?

A. The claim is fully correct, since only handwriting can force the summarization process described.

B. The claim locates the cause in the wrong place: summarization, not handwriting itself, appears to drive retention. ✓

C. The claim is irrelevant, since typing and handwriting produce identical outcomes in all situations.

D. The claim cannot be evaluated, since Text 2 does not measure retention.

Why: Text 1's claim: handwriting itself causes better retention. Text 2 isolates the real variable — once typing was forced to mimic handwriting's summarization behavior, it matched handwriting's results. That directly relocates the cause, which is a disagreement with Text 1's specific mechanism, not just a related finding.

Industrial-Era Nature Poetry

TEXT 1

A literary critic argues that nature poetry from the early industrial period consistently portrays machinery as an invasive, corrupting force, disrupting an otherwise pure natural landscape.

TEXT 2 (an original poem, "Iron Fields")

"The furnace glow at dusk becomes / another kind of evening star, / and even smoke, dispersed by wind, / finds patterns not unlike the birds'."

Based on the texts, how would the critic in Text 1 most likely respond to the poem in Text 2?

A. By arguing the poem confirms their claim, since it directly criticizes industrial machinery.

B. By suggesting the poem complicates their claim, since it depicts industrial imagery in harmonious, natural terms. ✓

C. By dismissing the poem as irrelevant to industrial-era nature poetry.

D. By claiming the poem was clearly not written during the industrial period.

Why: Look at the poem's actual comparisons: a furnace glow becomes a 'star,' and smoke's patterns echo 'the birds.' Both liken industry to nature harmoniously — the opposite of 'corrupting.' A single counter-example doesn't need to refute the critic's claim outright to complicate it.

Bike Lanes vs. Bus Transit

TEXT 1

A public health researcher recommends that cities invest primarily in expanding bike lane networks to reduce urban carbon emissions, citing bike lanes' low cost relative to public transit expansion.

TEXT 2

An analysis of twelve cities found that bike lane expansions increased cycling rates by an average of 12%, while comparable investments in bus rapid transit increased public transit ridership by an average of 34%, with correspondingly larger reductions in car commuting.

Based on the texts, which choice best describes how the data in Text 2 relates to the recommendation in Text 1?

A. It strongly supports Text 1's recommendation by showing bike lanes produce the largest emissions reductions.

B. It complicates Text 1's recommendation by suggesting bus rapid transit may produce larger ridership and emissions gains. ✓

C. It is entirely unrelated to Text 1's recommendation about bike lanes.

D. It proves that bike lane investments have no measurable effect on cycling rates.

Why: Don't just check whether bike lanes 'worked' (12% is still a real, positive number) — compare the SIZE of the effect against the alternative (34%). Text 2 doesn't refute bike lanes; it shows a bigger lever was available, which complicates 'invest primarily' in Text 1.

Libraries & Small Business Growth

TEXT 1

Economist Dana Wren argues that a city's investment in public libraries correlates with higher small-business formation rates in surrounding neighborhoods, citing the free business planning resources and meeting spaces libraries typically provide.

TEXT 2

A ten-year study found that neighborhoods within walking distance of a newly built library saw small-business formation rates rise by 22%, compared to just 6% in demographically similar neighborhoods without new library access.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to Wren's claim in Text 1?

A. By providing data broadly consistent with Wren's claim about libraries and business formation. ✓

B. By arguing that library funding has no relationship to local business outcomes.

C. By claiming the study measured an entirely different phenomenon than Wren discusses.

D. By asserting that business formation rates were identical with or without new libraries.

Why: Both texts point the same direction: library access associates with more new businesses. Text 2 adds a controlled comparison (22% vs. 6%) that reinforces, rather than complicates or contradicts, Wren's claim — a textbook 'agree' relationship, just with stronger evidence attached.

Open-Plan Offices & Collaboration

TEXT 1

A workplace consultant claims that open-plan office layouts increase spontaneous collaboration among employees compared to traditional walled offices, citing the ease of casual, in-person conversation.

TEXT 2

A study tracking employee communication with sociometric badges found that switching to open-plan offices reduced face-to-face interaction by roughly 70%, as employees increasingly turned to email and messaging apps to preserve a sense of privacy.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the consultant's claim in Text 1?

A. By agreeing, since both texts describe open-plan offices increasing employee interaction.

C. By arguing that email and messaging apps are inherently less effective than face-to-face conversation.

B. By presenting data that directly contradicts the claim that open-plan layouts increase in-person collaboration. ✓

D. By claiming that office layout has no measurable effect on communication of any kind.

Why: This is a clean disagreement, not just a complication. The consultant claims MORE spontaneous collaboration; the tracked data shows interaction fell roughly 70% — a direct, measured contradiction of the specific mechanism claimed, not a side issue or a qualifying exception.

Mangrove Forests & Reef Health

TEXT 1

A marine biologist documents that coral reefs located near mangrove forests recover from bleaching events measurably faster than reefs without nearby mangroves, attributing this to the shelter and nutrient cycling mangroves provide.

TEXT 2

A follow-up study found that mangrove-adjacent reefs also supported significantly higher fish biodiversity even outside of bleaching recovery periods — a benefit unrelated to bleaching resilience specifically.

Based on the texts, which choice best describes how the finding in Text 2 relates to the claim in Text 1?

A. It contradicts Text 1 by showing mangroves provide no benefit to reef health.

C. It qualifies Text 1 by showing the bleaching-recovery benefit only occurs in certain seasons.

B. It extends Text 1 by identifying an additional, separate ecological benefit of mangrove-adjacent reefs. ✓

D. It is unrelated to Text 1's discussion of mangroves and reef health.

Why: Text 2 doesn't challenge or narrow Text 1's specific claim about bleaching recovery — it leaves that intact and adds a new, separate benefit (biodiversity) in a different context (non-bleaching periods). New consistent angle, no contradiction: that's an extension, not a qualification or disagreement.

The Printing Press & the Reformation

TEXT 1 (underlined claim shown)

Some historians have argued that the printing press alone was sufficient to cause the Reformation's rapid spread across Europe, pointing to the sheer volume of pamphlets printed in the decades after Gutenberg's invention.

TEXT 2

A book historian notes that literacy rates in most regions where the Reformation spread fastest were below 10%, suggesting the press's impact depended heavily on oral sermon networks that relayed printed content to overwhelmingly illiterate populations.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1?

A. By agreeing that the press alone fully explains the Reformation's rapid spread.

B. By arguing that printed pamphlets played no meaningful role in spreading the Reformation.

C. By suggesting the press's effect depended on oral networks, complicating the claim that it alone was sufficient. ✓

D. By claiming that literacy rates were actually far higher than most historians assume.

Why: Cross-text questions sometimes underline one specific sentence rather than a whole passage — answer about THAT sentence only. The underlined claim says the press ALONE was sufficient. Text 2's low-literacy data shows an additional necessary ingredient (oral relay), which narrows 'alone,' without denying the press mattered at all.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Three Things to Remember

- 1 Paraphrase both texts into one plain sentence each — do this before you ever look at the choices.
- 2 Name the relationship (agree / disagree / extend / qualify) in your own words, and test each choice against that prediction.
- 3 Trust a strong match. If a choice fits your prediction, don't be shaken by a fancier-sounding option or an unfamiliar word in another choice.